

SP

Amar Singh

STYLE Dramatic, no doubt inspired by the company he often keeps

FAVOURITE

PHRASE *Tum agar mujhko na chaho to koi baat nahin, tum kisi aur ko chaahogi to mushkil hogi*

CPI(M)

Brinda Karat

STYLE Handloom activist who suffers from an excess of righteousness

FAVOURITE PHRASE But the CPI(M) has always been saying this

Sitaram Yechury

STYLE Chatty professor who loves telling stories, sometimes repetitively

FAVOURITE PHRASE This is a fight between suffering India and shining India

evening, so that the Congress spokesperson can speak to at least three channels a day, practising sound argument, not loud argument.

In keeping with the noise level of these elections, the debates have become shorter, the panels longer. Most spokespersons don't get more than three minutes of speech time, for which they have to learn to speak fast. The plethora of spokespersons means the seniors can now choose the channels and times, which they do, sometimes to the annoyance of many veteran journalists who have witnessed their hustling for bytes in the past. Some seniors have also been excluded from TV's easy fame by the electioneering process, like Swaraj, who has set up temporary base in Bhopal, while others such as Jaitley wasted time in a prolonged sulk with the party. Some also come to

the studios only after a bit of cajoling from editors. Guest coordinators, even the persistent ones, are strictly not entertained.

The prime time politicians are doing their best to compete with the girls in peril on TV soaps, and soon they will have the boys in black, blue and yellow as well. But not only are they hampered by the absence of a single national issue that has caught the imagination of the people but also by the largely trivial issues masking as The Big Debates of the Day. There is only so much that can be said about Varun Gandhi's hate speech and Manmohan Singh's outbursts, apart from cheering or jeering. So tedious have some panels become that there are debates about precisely this issue sometimes: why are there no issues? Then the regional parties suffer from a singular lack of representation. Mayawati in a television studio, with or without handbag, is unthinkable; Dayanidhi Maran is perky but insubstantial; Vaiko only issues

threats; J. Jayalalithaa only grants an audience to a fortunate few and the Fourth Front leaders are too busy winning the battle on the ground to fight the war on the airwaves. Other speakers such as the often hysterical Mohammed Salim of the CPI(M) and D. Raja of the CPI, who tends to begin every sentence, even in the affirmative, with "No", are hampered by the parties they are in, while the delightfully rude Mani Shankar Aiyar is clearly too smart for the Congress media cell. And sadly for viewers looking for comic relief, BJP's M. Venkaiah Naidu, the triple-rhyming sensation of the 2004 elections, of whom it was said that every time he spoke the party lost three votes, is busy as convener of his party's central election management committee.

And though the television debates lack drama on screen, there seems to be enough happening behind the scenes. Television presenters speak of tantrums senior leaders throw when asked to participate in debates on Hindi channels, some hissy fits they throw on sets (as Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi recently did, almost walking off a news channel show), and even some conditions they state (varying from the quality of the panel to the kind of tea they drink). And yes, they also speak of two conversation-stopping questions: for BJP it is what Advani wrote in his autobiography on Kandahar and for the Congress, it is why Afzal Guru has not been hanged. ■